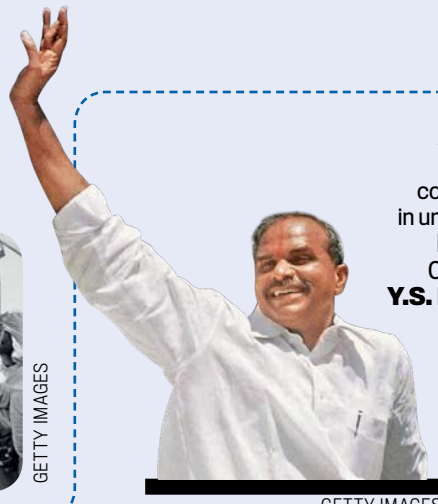


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GETTY IMAGES

2003

A three-month-long padayatra covering 1,475 km in undivided Andhra Pradesh helped Congress leader **Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy** win the assembly election next year and become CM



2012

TDP chief **N. Chandrababu Naidu** covered nearly 2,000 km in undivided Andhra Pradesh and was re-elected in 2014

2017-18

YSRCP chief **Y. S. Jaganmohan Reddy** walked 3,648 km in Andhra Pradesh in 341 days, and his party swept the 2019 polls





2017-18

Though dubbed a spiritual journey, former Madhya Pradesh chief minister **Digvijaya Singh** completed a 192-day, 3,300 km-long Narmada Parikrama Yatra across the state on foot in April 2018. The Congress won the assembly election held later that year

PANKAJ TIWARI

TO BUILD ON THE ADVANTAGES OF THE YATRA, THE CONGRESS MUST NOW BUILD AN ALTERNATIVE POLITICAL AND ECONOMIC NARRATIVE ON THE ISSUES IT RAISED

Political Science, Ashoka University, though, disagrees. He says the yatra's impact has been limited to just neutralising Rahul Gandhi's negative image.

THE DIVIDENDS OF THE YATRA

That Rahul's image has improved after the yatra is evident from the CVoter survey that tracked his ratings in states pre and post the event. The respondents were asked whether they were satisfied with his political performance, and the results showed a V-shaped recovery for Rahul in some states. So, while in Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka and MP, where Rahul already enjoyed high ratings ranging from 55 per cent to 62 per cent, his popularity remained stable or even went up, in other states such as Haryana, Punjab, Maharashtra and UP, where his ratings averaged 40 per cent, they went up by 6-8 percentage points following the yatra. However, in Rajasthan, a state going to the polls, his ratings dropped by three percentage points and by nine in Delhi.

The good news for Rahul is that his all-India ratings have touched 50 per cent in January 2023, an impressive increase of 10 percentage points compared to January 2022, though still short of the high of 54.5 per cent he reached in January 2019. A sobering finding, however, is that when asked who was better suited to be the prime minister, Narendra Modi or Rahul Gandhi, the prime minister's rating was seen to have gone up from 54.3 per cent to 60.8 per cent after the yatra, while Rahul's increased only marginally to 29.9 per cent, indicating the yawning gulf that remains between him and Modi. And as Yashwant Deshmukh, founder chairman, CVoter, points out, "Even with the high 2019 ratings, Rahul Gandhi could not make Congress win the general election or even pose a significant challenge to the BJP." He believes that the yatra was not so much about defeating the BJP in 2024 but mitigating the threat posed by the surge of the Arvind Kejriwal-led AAP and reinforcing the fact that the Congress remains the principal Opposition party in the country and is still relevant.

In a separate INDIA TODAY-CVoter Mood of the Nation poll, when asked to give their assessment of the Bharat Jodo Yatra, 29 per cent believed it was a great exercise by the party for mass connect. But a substantial 36.8 per cent, while conceding that the yatra had created a buzz, believed that the party didn't have the organisational muscle and leadership to win elections. The message is clear: the Congress has to undertake a massive organisational overhaul if it has to pose a challenge to the BJP, whether at the state or at the national level. "The Congress has always been a party of movements and not cadre. Any successful movement has to be supplemented by an effective organisation," says Digvijaya Singh. Prof. Hasan cannot agree more. "For the yatra to translate into anything fruitful for the party," she says, "there is a need for serious changes within. The yatra is the necessary first step in building a politics of change.